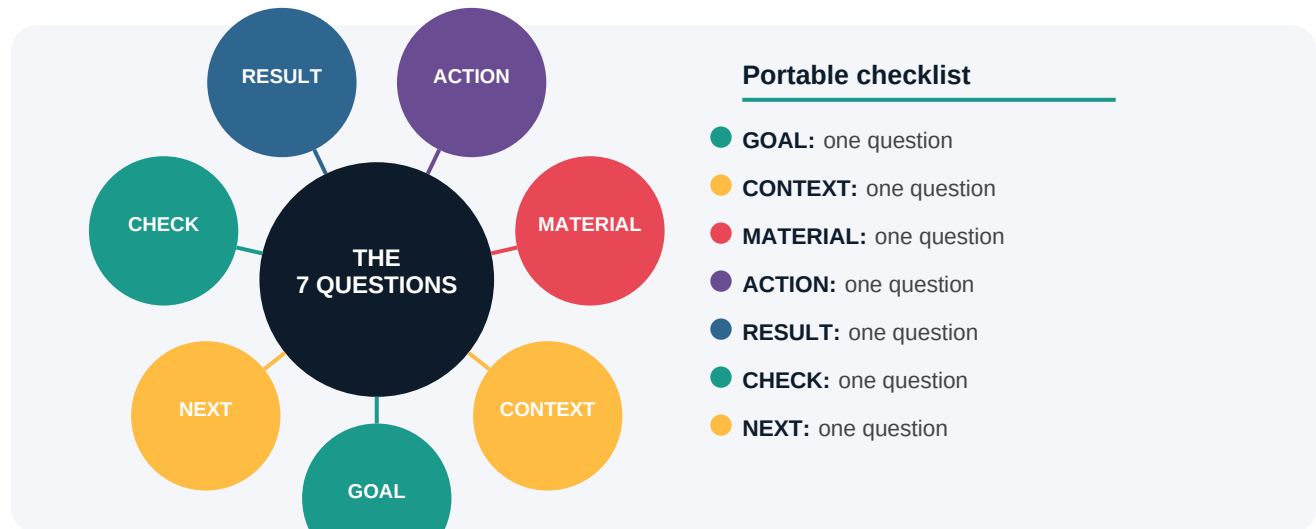


The 7 Questions, Your Portable AI Framework



A FRAMEWORK YOU CAN CARRY IN YOUR HEAD The AI Interaction Stack gives you a complete map. But maps aren't always what you need. Sometimes you need a quick checklist, something you can run through in sixty seconds before an important interaction.

The 7 Questions is that checklist.

It is derived from the stack but simplified into seven questions that cover the most important dimensions of any significant AI interaction. It is short enough to memorise. It is structured enough to catch the most common input failures. And it is abstract enough to work on any AI platform, with any model, now or in the future.

THE 7 QUESTIONS A quick checklist before any significant AI interaction.

Q1 What am I trying to Q2 What does AI need to achieve? know?

Q3 What information can I Q4 What exactly should AI provide? do?

Q5 What should the result Q6 How will I check it? look like?

Q7 What should happen next?

THE 7 QUESTIONS Before any significant AI interaction:

- WHAT AM I TRYING TO ACHIEVE?
- State the underlying goal, not just the surface task. "I want my

- CEO to approve the budget" is more useful than "I want a summary." The goal shapes every other decision.
- WHAT DOES AI NEED TO KNOW?
 - What background information, constraints, relationships, or context is essential to getting a good output? What would a capable human assistant need to know before starting this task?
- WHAT INFORMATION CAN I PROVIDE?
 - What documents, data, notes, examples, or materials exist that would make AI's output more specific and more accurate? What can you attach or paste in?
- WHAT EXACTLY SHOULD AI DO?
 - What is the specific action? Not "help with", do. Write, summarise, extract, compare, analyse, rewrite, draft, plan. Be precise about the verb and the scope.
- WHAT SHOULD THE RESULT LOOK LIKE?
 - Format, length, tone, structure, audience, medium. If you do not specify, AI will choose. Specify.
- HOW WILL I CHECK IT?
 - What might be wrong? What specifically needs verification before you use or share this output? Are there numbers, dates, names, claims, or recommendations that require checking?
- WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN NEXT?
 - Is this one step in a larger process? What will you do with this output? Will it become input to another AI prompt, a document you share, or a decision you make?



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

WHY IT WORKS EACH QUESTION ADDRESSES A DIFFERENT FAILURE MODE. QUESTION 1 CATCHES THE WRONG GOAL. QUESTIONS 2-7 CATCH THE OTHER FAILURE MODES.

You can have a perfect answer to six questions and fail on the seventh. The framework is complete by design.

USING THE 7 QUESTIONS: A WORKED EXAMPLE Sarah needs to create a briefing document on a potential new supplier for her director.

Let's run through the questions:

Q1, WHAT AM I TRYING TO ACHIEVE? My director needs to decide whether to invite this supplier to a formal tender. I need to give her the information required to make that decision, not a complete company profile.

Q2, WHAT DOES AI NEED TO KNOW? The decision context (tender shortlist), the supplier's name (TechFlow Ltd), what the tender is for (CRM software implementation), our current system (Salesforce), our rough budget (£80,000), and what factors matter most to us (integration capability, support quality, UK presence).

Q3, WHAT INFORMATION CAN I PROVIDE? I have the supplier's website, a brochure they sent us, and notes from a call I took with their sales contact last week.

Chapter 3 - The 7 Questions, Your Portable AI Framework

Q4, WHAT EXACTLY SHOULD AI DO? Create a supplier briefing document using the materials I provide. Organised under the headings: Company Overview, Relevant Experience, Key Capabilities, Potential Risks, Recommended Questions to Ask.

Q5, WHAT SHOULD THE RESULT LOOK LIKE? One page, maximum. Professional but plain language. My director doesn't have time for anything longer. Bullet points under each heading.

Q6, HOW WILL I CHECK IT? I'll verify any specific facts against the brochure and my call notes. I'll flag for my director any claims from the supplier that couldn't be independently verified.

Q7, WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN NEXT? This document will go to my director for her review. If she decides to proceed, I'll use AI to help draft the invitation to tender based on the same materials.

Now Sarah turns this into a prompt:

"I need a one-page supplier briefing document for my director, who is deciding whether to include TechFlow Ltd in a CRM software tender shortlist. The tender is for an implementation project with a rough budget of £80,000. Our current system is Salesforce.

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- The document should be organised under these five headings:
- Company Overview, Relevant Experience, Key Capabilities,
- Potential Risks, Recommended Questions to Ask.

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- Please work from the materials I am attaching: [brochure], [call notes]. Plain language, bullet points, maximum one page. Flag
- any claims in the supplier's materials that you cannot
- independently verify from what I've provided."



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

This is a complete interaction. It took about three minutes to prepare using the 7 Questions. It would have taken considerably longer to produce a good result any other way.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE James is a recent graduate preparing for a job interview. He runs through the 7 Questions:

Q1, I want to walk into this interview well-prepared, able to give specific answers about why I want this role. Q2, The company is Meridian Digital, a mid-size marketing agency. The role is Junior Account Manager. My background is a marketing degree and six months of internship experience. The interview is in two days. Q3, I have the job description, the company's website, their LinkedIn page, and a Glassdoor page with recent employee reviews. Q4, I want AI to help me prepare for likely interview questions, draft answers to the hardest ones, and identify things about the company I should know. Q5, I want a structured prep document: company background summary, ten likely questions with draft answers, and a section on questions I should ask them. Q6, I'll verify any company facts against their current website before the interview. Q7, I'll use the document to do a practice run the night before.

The resulting prompt takes forty seconds to write. The output he gets is interview prep he can actually use, not generic "tell me about a time you overcame a challenge" boilerplate.

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THE 7 QUESTIONS AS A PORTABLE CARD The 7 Questions are reproduced as a reference card in Appendix A. You can photograph it, print it, or simply remember it. The goal is that it becomes automatic, something you run through mentally before any AI interaction that matters.

You do not need to answer every question in full every time. For a simple, low-stakes task, three or four seconds on each question is sufficient. For a complex, high-stakes task, a document going to a senior stakeholder, a recommendation with significant consequences, a piece of work that will be published, the full seven questions deserve a full minute each.

PRO TIP ONCE YOU HAVE A WELL-DEVELOPED ANSWER TO THE 7 QUESTIONS FOR A RECURRING TASK, A WEEKLY REPORT,

WATCH OUT THE 7 QUESTIONS ARE A PREPARATION TOOL, NOT A RIGID PROTOCOL. IF YOU FIND YOURSELF SPENDING TEN



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI